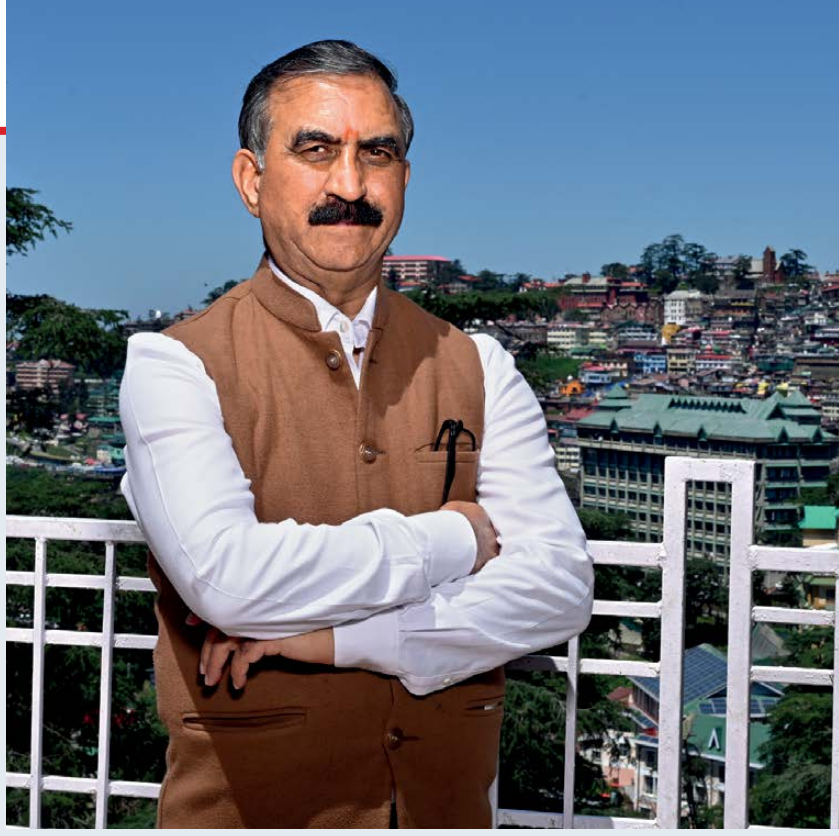
THE POPULATION OF SHIMLA HAS BALLOONED TO 300,000 IN A CITY THAT WAS MEANT TO HOLD 50,000. THE HILL TOWN ALSO HAS 80,000 TOURISTS VISITING IT ON ANY GIVEN DAY

capital. Post-Partition, the city was also the capital of Punjab, till the state constructed Chandigarh and moved there. For long, the elite in north India had their summer houses here, spending large parts of the year (from March till November) at the hill station. Even for the Indian middle class, Shimla topped their excursion wish list.

Today, the city's population has ballooned to around 300,000 (the 2011 census put the number of residents at 241,429) in a city built to hold around 50,000. On any given day, Shimla also bears the burden of roughly 80,000 tourists as well as a floating population visiting the city for work. Over the years, Shimla has also turned itself into a grotesque urban sprawl of haphazard buildings. Unlike the capitals of other Himalayan states that are situated in a plateau or valley, Shimla is spread across seven hills. It is also a tourism hot spot, home to the state's high court, an education hub, as well as a fruits acceleration point and mandi. All this attracts settlers, adding to the pressure on the hills.

According to state government officials, several areas in the Shimla district, as well as the town, are sinking. The situation is reportedly grave in the villages of Labrot, Khauni, Chanderpur and Ghunsa in Jubbal;



INTERVIEW: SUKHVINDER SINGH SUKHU

'The floods must be declared a national calamity'

Himachal Pradesh chief minister ***Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu*** *of the Congress is in the first year of his term, but is already weathering a major crisis. The recent flash floods have put the focus back on the hill state's fragile ecology. In an interview with* ***Anilesh S. Mahajan****, the CM agrees that a course correction is needed. Excerpts:*

Q. After the recent natural disasters, many people are questioning the development model the hill states are pursuing...

A. I have lived almost all my life in Shimla. The 'intellectuals' have been writing columns about environmental disasters, but the planned areas in Shimla—where the structures have followed engineering principles—have seen no damage. My belief is that if we ignore structural planning, there will be consequences. Two things are crucial—the soil strata where construction is happening and its load-bearing capacity. Shimla was the summer capital of the British and the current eight-storeyed civil secretariat was built during their time. It was constructed on hard strata. There are other issues as well, such as people getting the architectural drawings cleared at the local government level without consulting the engineers, and the absence of drainage systems. There are shortcomings on the government side too—we should have tested whether specific areas are fit for construction or not.